under Indian administrative control. Even though the Assam Rifles was under the Ministry of External Affairs, which in turn was headed by the prime minister, there is little doubt that Nehru had not been informed. By the time he found out what was happening, Bob Khathing was already in Tawang.

Nehru was furious. Fait accompli or not, his immediate act was to summon the governor and yell at him. Shaken, the Assam government lost its nerve. On 25 April, when Lhasa responded on the issue, both Delhi and Shillong were imploring Khathing not to do anything ‘without consulting us’.

Lhasa instructed the Tsona dzongpen to dig in and hold his ground. Accordingly, the Tibetans ordered all village chiefs to assemble at Tawang. However, by then, Bob Khathing and the Assam Rifles had made a favourable impression on the Monpas. To further underline his authority, Khathing staged a flag march where fifty men with their rifles and gleaming bayonets marched through Tawang. The meeting called by the dzongpen was a failure, with few village chiefs backing the Tibetans. Seizing the moment, Khathing put in an appearance and firmly told the Tsona dzongpen and the other Tibetan officials that they would be escorted to the Indian border post at Khenzemane. Should they venture to cross back into Indian territory without the administration’s permission, they would be arrested.

New Delhi now had administrative control over the whole of NEFA. After the incident, Nehru summoned Khathing and vented his anger, demanding to know who exactly had instructed Khathing to take matters into his own hands. Nehru’s reaction was fast becoming typical; even on the larger question of China and Tibet, the prime minister, in keeping with his image as a man of peace, refused to publicly castigate China despite the fact that all committees set up to study the situation on the northern border were indicating that a clash with the Chinese was a distinct possibility.

The implementation of the suggestions made by the Himmatsinhji Committee was not always easy. There were continuing intelligence reports that indicated increased covert Chinese activity in various parts of NEFA. As the Indian government moved to expand the administration beyond the ‘inner line’, there was considerable resentment against ‘the intrusion by the plainsmen’, and Chinese agents exploited this, with tragic consequences. North of Daporijo and astride the Subansiri River in the Siang Frontier Division was a large pocket of territory that had not been surveyed at the